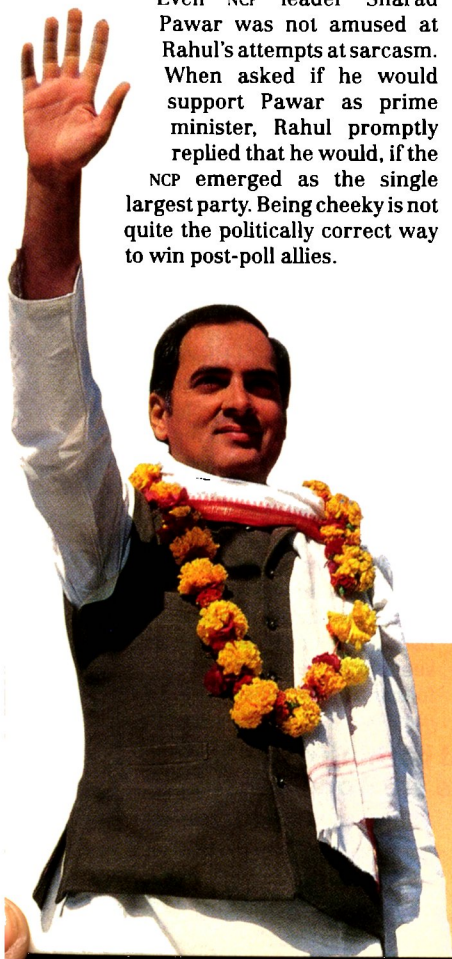


ELECT 2009

Cover story RAHUL GANDHI

RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav, LJP leader Ram Vilas Paswan and Trinamool Congress's Mamata Banerjee were not too pleased at this rather amateur attempt to replace them with their regional foes. An irate Paswan demanded why Rahul was fielding candidates against Nitish if he was doing such good work while the mercurial Banerjee saw this as yet another example of the use-and-discard brand of politics that the Congress is notorious for. Questioning the timing of Rahul's comments, Trinamool leader Partha Chatterjee pointed out that these have come at a time when two phases of the West Bengal polls are still left. "Such comments are not responsible from such a leader. It's strange that these comments come when polling in constituencies where the Congress put up candidates is over," he said.

Even NCP leader Sharad Pawar was not amused at Rahul's attempts at sarcasm. When asked if he would support Pawar as prime minister, Rahul promptly replied that he would, if the NCP emerged as the single largest party. Being cheeky is not quite the politically correct way to win post-poll allies.



A Congress general secretary, however, says that there could be a method in Rahul's madness. He sees this as a careful strategy chalked out by the mother and son, and not an off-the-cuff statement. "By our calculations, both Lalu and Paswan are not expected to retain their tally in Bihar. Both could lose in their own constituencies. The situation in Andhra is not good for the Congress. Given this scenario, it makes sense to woo new allies," he explained. Whether Rahul's comment was political opportunism or a stray

soundbite, from the confusion that followed, it was clear that this was not a unanimous party strategy. And it is not that Sonia has handed over the reins of the party to her son. This is just the first phase of the takeover which began during the last round of assembly elections when Sonia stepped back and let Rahul emerge as the star campaigner. Now another dimension is being added to his public persona—that of a decision-maker. Rahul has always played a crucial role in the party's leadership process. But ear-

Like Father **LIKE SON** Not only his dimples, Rahul has

THE DEBUT A reluctant politician who took the plunge to "help mummy" after brother Sanjay's death. An Indian Airlines pilot, he studied at Doon and Cambridge.

POLITICAL GRAPH An MP at 36, he took charge of the youth wings as general secretary. Became India's youngest PM at 40. Often got into trouble for his off-the-cuff statements.

PET ISSUES Lowered the voting age to 18 and ushered in the computer age. Began dismantling the licence raj. Was against caste and religion-based reservations.